

JAGJIT SINGH KAPOOR

57, BEEKEEPER

MD, KASHMIR APIARIES

INITIAL INVESTMENT IN 1980 Rs 1,000

CURRENT TURNOVER Rs 136 crore

role MODEL

Dhirubhai Ambani's story of braving all odds inspires him

big DREAM

To export honey and byproducts to 100 countries by 2010

success MANTRA

Sharing his knowledge with beekeepers, his real stakeholders



VIKRAM SHARMA

SWEET SUCCESS

Even in a great depression, Kashmir Apiaries, India's largest honey exporting company is buzzing with enthusiasm, aiming at trebling its exports from Rs 136 crore to Rs 400 crore by March next year. Asia's biggest beekeeping company, with 25,000 colonies, adorns its office near Doraha in Punjab's Ludhiana district with a plethora of award certificates, proof of being the nation's largest honey exporter for eight years in a row. It alone contributes 70 per cent of India's annual exports of 22,000 tonnes of honey.

Though his family was uprooted by the Partition, Jagjit Singh Kapoor never let it come in the way of his ambition, starting with only five bee colonies to become one of the world's busiest migratory beekeeping companies. His colonies move between states according to flower seasons to produce 5,000 tonnes of organic honey every year. Though taking off was easy, finding a buyer wasn't as he struggled to market his first production of 50 kg. Now his honey sells under four brand names and 140-odd private labels in 42 countries, placing his

company Kashmir Apiaries, among the world's top five honey processors.

"Having complete knowledge of beekeeping has helped me master the business," says Kapoor modestly. Nearly 1,500 workers manage the collection, processing, labelling and marketing the honey to handling the research, training and outreach. His backbone comprises a nationwide network involving thousands of small honey producers. "We gather honey from Kashmir to Kanyakumari," says his son Shahzada Singh, 35. Kapoor ramped up exports by importing technology to improve the quality. He even designed a drier for reduction of moisture content and developed a colony feeder. His latest acquisitions are an automatic honey extraction unit and a Chinese kit to detect contamination. "I share all my knowledge with the beekeepers because they are the real stakeholders in my business," says Kapoor. His plans include exporting to 100 countries by 2010 and marketing high-value byproducts like royal jelly and bee venom. All of them are likely to keep him as busy as a bee. *by Ramesh Vinayak*

KAPOOR COULD NOT SELL HIS FIRST PRODUCE OF 50 KG

HONEY IN 1981 DUE TO LACK OF MARKETING SKILLS AND HAD TO FEED MOST OF IT TO THE BEES